

Arizona - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG 12

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Solid top-35 team with a proven quarterback and staff continuity, but a materially lower defensive certainty than the 2025 results
Preseason consensus	AP Others receiving votes (32) · SP+ No. 31
Returning production	60% (No. 34) overall · Off. 66% (No. 22) · Def. 55% (No. 58)
Primer power rating	+9.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	7.6 wins · likely 8-4
Net vs. 2025	● ↓ Worse, primarily because the elite 2025 defense must replace unusually heavy secondary talent
Confidence	Medium-high

2026 identity: Arizona should lean on QB Noah Fifita in Seth Doege's tempo-and-vertical offense, with the late RB Ismail Mahdi return and RB Kedrick Reescano giving the run game multiple options and the tight-end room offering heavier personnel packages.

Bottom line: Arizona has enough continuity at quarterback, coaching and linebacker to remain a good Big 12 team, but the Wildcats are more likely to live around the top-30 range than reproduce a 2025 defense that lost a remarkable amount of NFL-bound secondary talent.

Beats expectations if: QB Noah Fifita turns the returning/transfer receiver mix into a consistent downfield offense, the OL settles around OL Zach Henning and OT Tristan Bounds, and CB Jay'Vion Cole plus S/NB Malcolm Hartzog stabilize a secondary that lost multiple NFL players.

Disappoints if: The OL turnover creates too many negative passing situations, the reworked secondary cannot approach the 2025 explosive-play and pass-efficiency standard, and the late eligibility returns of RB Ismail Mahdi/Harris become unavailable or less stable than the current roster picture.

Five things to remember

- 1 ★ **QB Noah Fifita:** QB Noah Fifita is the clear returning starter and carries Big 12 preseason first-team recognition plus Maxwell/Walter Camp watchlists.
- 2 ? **Defensive availability:** RB Ismail Mahdi and LB Max Harris are current roster members after a federal fifth-year eligibility ruling; the cited report also preserved an NCAA appeal contingency.
- 3 **NFL departures:** The 2025 defense was genuinely excellent-adjusted defense No.13, defensive EPA/play No.13, havoc No.7 and pass-efficiency defense No.1-but the secondary lost multiple NFL-bound starters/contributors.
- 4 **Returning production:** Offensive returning production is 66% (No.22), but the final OL five remains unsettled and the receiving corps must replace WR Luke Wysong, WR Kris Hutson and WR Javin Whatley.
- 5 **Schedule pressure:** The schedule is moderate by Power Four standards (SOS No.45, 6/10), but the late run at Texas Tech, TCU, Utah and at Kansas State will decide whether Arizona is merely bowl-safe or a Big 12 factor.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	9-4 (7-3 Big 12)	● Good
Scoring	31.5 PPG	● Very good
Total offense	407.6 YPG	● Good / above average
Rush offense	152.4 YPG · 4.3 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass efficiency	7.44 YPA · 29 TD / 8 INT	● Good / above average
Third downs	41.0%	● Average / mixed
Scoring defense	19.3 PPG allowed	● Very good
Total defense	308.5 YPG allowed	● Very good
Rush defense	143.2 YPG · 3.9 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass defense	165.3 YPG · 5.58 YPA · 9 TD allowed	● Elite

Arizona was a balanced winning team by conventional measures: scoring offense No.30 and total offense No.42, while the defense ranked No.21 in scoring and No.19 in total defense. The standout traditional number was pass-efficiency defense at No.1 nationally.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+5.97 · No. 18	● Very good
Off. EPA/play	+0.077 · No. 38	● Good / above average
Off. success rate	42.6% · No. 69	● Average / mixed
Off. explosive-play rate	13.6% · No. 32	● Very good
Havoc allowed	14.6% · No. 58	● Average / mixed
Opp.-adjusted defense	+7.46 · No. 13	● Elite
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.150 · No. 13	● Elite
Def. success rate allowed	37.3% · No. 23	● Very good
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	9.0% · No. 16	● Very good
Havoc created	20.0% · No. 7	● Elite

Advanced-stat read: Arizona’s 2025 offense was good but not consistently dominant-opponent adjustment (No.18) was stronger than EPA (No.38) and success rate (No.69). The defense was the real engine: top-13 adjusted/EPA, top-25 success defense, No.16 explosive prevention and No.7 havoc. That creates a clear 2026 regression risk because the roster turnover is concentrated in the very secondary that powered the elite pass-defense results.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Brent Brennan - returning head coach	● ↔ Continuity supports a stable preseason projection
OC / offensive play-caller	Seth Doege - returning OC/QB coach; offensive play-caller for a second season	● ↔ Offensive play-calling continuity supports the unit baseline
DC / defensive play-caller	Danny Gonzales - returning defensive coordinator; defensive play-caller	● ↔ Defensive play-calling responsibility is settled within the staff

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ OL Zach Henning	Washington	● ↔ Starting center and a key stabilizer in an otherwise unsettled OL.
◆ WR Rodney Gallagher III	West Virginia	● ↔ Transfer slot/major-role candidate who helps replace substantial receiver departures.

Out	To	Loss
C Ka'ena Decambra	NFL (Arizona), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Material center departure on a confirmed NFL path.
OT Ty Buchanan	No pro signing established	● ↓ Meaningful 2025 tackle leaves with no signed destination established.
WR Luke Wysong	NFL (Minnesota), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Significant receiver departs via a Vikings UDFA path.
WR Kris Hutson	No pro signing established	● ↓ Substantial 2025 receiver leaves with no signed destination established.

Offensive net: stable at QB/RB but less proven at WR and OL

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ S/NB Malcolm Hartzog	Nebraska	● ↔ Secured the nickel role and supplies needed experience in a rebuilt secondary.
◆ S Daylen Austin	Oregon	● ↔ Current roster addition with major-role/competition relevance in a secondary replacing multiple pros.

Out	To	Loss
S Treydan Stukes	NFL (Las Vegas), Round 2, No. 38	● ↓ Material 2025 secondary contributor leaves on a NFL path.
S Dalton Johnson	NFL (Las Vegas), Round 5, No. 150	● ↓ Meaningful safety and NFL draft departure.
S Genesis Smith	NFL (L.A. Chargers), Round 4, No. 131	● ↓ Another material safety loss from an elite 2025 pass defense.
CB Michael Dansby	NFL (Seattle), Round 7, No. 255	● ↓ Significant corner loss to Seattle as a seventh-round draft pick.
CB Ayden Garnes	NFL (Tampa Bay), undrafted free agent	● ↓ The 13-start corner leaves as a Tampa Bay UDFA.

Defensive net: clear downgrade from an elite 2025 baseline, especially in the secondary

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Tempo and vertical stress around QB Noah Fifita, with flexibility to use more multi-TE personnel if the room earns it.	Returning QB plus a deep RB picture after RB Ismail Mahdi's return; enough receiver candidates to distribute targets.	Final OL five is unsettled and the receiver room replaces multiple material departures.
Defense	DC Danny Gonzales returns to call a defense built on disruption and pass suppression.	LB Taye Brown and LB Max Harris anchor a veteran front-seven spine, with improved front depth.	The secondary must replace an extraordinary volume of departures to professional football, with the second outside corner still open.
Special teams	Punter is identified, but the broader specialist picture is unsettled.	P Chase Ridley is the starter.	Placekicker is unresolved and SP+ special teams ranks No. 119.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B+	● ↔	High	QB Noah Fifita gives Arizona stable 13-game continuity at the offense's most important position.
RB	● B+	● ↑	Medium-high	RB Ismail Mahdi's fifth-year return raises both the ceiling and depth of an already useful room.
WR	● B-	● ↓	Medium	WR Tre Spivey leads a reshaped group trying to preserve the offense's tempo and vertical stress.
TE	● B-	● ↔	Medium	Multi-TE flexibility gives the offense useful personnel options, but no featured star is established.
OL	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	OT Tristan Bounds is a continuity anchor while the final five and left side are rebuilt.
DL/Edge	● B-	● ↓	Medium	Improved front depth helps, but major departures leave less proven continuity than in 2025.
LB	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	LB Taye Brown anchors a veteran group asked to protect a much less proven secondary.
Secondary	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	CB Jay'Vion Cole leads a back end replacing multiple NFL-bound players and still sorting its second corner.
Special teams	● C	● ↔	Low	P Chase Ridley is settled, but placekicker remains unresolved.
Coaching	● B+	● ↔	High	Staff continuity lowers transition risk on both sides of the ball.
Overall	● B	● ↓	Medium-high	Solid top-35 team with a proven quarterback and staff continuity, but a materially lower defensive certainty than the 2025 results

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through August 24, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Noah Fifita	QB	● High-end conference starter	Big 12 preseason 1st team · Maxwell · Walter Camp Player of the Year	Returning 13-game starter and the stabilizing reason Arizona can withstand turnover elsewhere.
Taye Brown	LB	● National-impact linebacker candidate	Bednarik · Nagurski · Butkus	Returning defensive leader and the most decorated player in a front seven asked to cover for secondary turnover.
Ismail Mahdi	RB	● High-leverage eligibility return	-	Returned for a fifth season under a federal ruling, materially changing the RB ceiling and depth picture.
Kedrick Reescano	RB	● High-upside major-role back	Doak Walker	A recognized returning back whose workload now shares the spotlight with Mahdi rather than carrying a forced RB1 label.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Tristan Bounds	OT	● Experienced OL anchor	Outland	One of the few clear continuity anchors as the final five and left side are rebuilt.
Tre Spivey	WR	● Major-role returning receiver	-	One of the primary returning targets in an offense trying to preserve tempo/vertical stress after receiver turnover.
Jay'Vion Cole	CB	● Top returning corner	-	Late-camp reporting identifies him as the top corner in a secondary replacing multiple NFL-bound players.
Malcolm Hartzog	S/NB	● Experienced nickel stabilizer	-	Transfer addition who secured the nickel role and supplies needed experience in the rebuilt back end.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Manageable relative to the league, with the most difficult games clustered late
Difficulty	● 6/10 · SP+ SOS No. 45
Hardest stretch	at Texas Tech → TCU → Utah → at Kansas State
Swing games	at BYU, TCU, Utah, at Kansas State, Arizona State
Advantage	The Oct. 17 bye precedes the final six-game run; TCU, Utah and Arizona State all come at home.
Expected	7.6 wins · likely 8-4
Floor / ceiling	6-6 / 10-2

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Arizona's 9-4 record and returning quarterback can attract continuity pricing, but SP+ No.31 and defensive personnel turnover argue against assuming the 2025 defense simply repeats.
Back them when	The price treats Arizona as a merely average offense despite QB Noah Fifita continuity, especially against opponents that cannot exploit the unsettled OL or force the rebuilt secondary into repeated isolated coverage.
Fade/pass when	The market prices last year's No.1 pass-efficiency defense as fully repeatable before the new secondary proves itself, or when the Wildcats must protect QB Noah Fifita behind an unsettled line against a strong pass rush.
Key monitor	final OL five, RB split after RB Ismail Mahdi return, second outside corner, placekicker, RB Ismail Mahdi/LB Max Harris eligibility context
Week 1 baseline	vs. Northern Arizona: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Arizona -31.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Arizona has a stable offensive centerpiece in QB Noah Fifita, with RB Ismail Mahdi's return and RB Kedrick Reescano giving the run game useful depth. Staff continuity and LB Taye Brown also provide important anchors.

The ceiling depends on an unsettled OL and a rebuilt secondary replacing exceptional 2025 production. Arizona still looks like a solid top-35 Big 12 team, with 8-4 the most likely record rather than an automatic repeat of last year's defensive dominance.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching staff](#) · [eligibility update](#) · [WR preview](#) · [DC update](#) · [OL preview](#) · [DL preview](#) · [CB update](#)

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